

> **“We did not start this war [in Ukraine]. The West egged Ukraine on and supported the events, orchestrating the coup d’etat”**

> **“President Zelensky follows the same pattern as his predecessors—putting the interests of radical nationalists ahead of those of the people”**

> **“Each country, including Ukraine, has the right to choose its own means of defence. But it’s not acceptable if it’s done at Russia’s expense”**

we should engage in this effort rather than obstruct it.

Q. What happened in Alaska with President Trump? Was he serious and sincere about the peace deal?
A. I have absolutely no doubt that President Trump had genuine intentions. Both the United States and President Trump likely have their own understanding of why this needs to be resolved quickly. On humanitarian grounds too. I truly believe that is one of the motives behind President Trump’s actions regarding this matter because he constantly speaks about his wish to minimise losses. However, other factors also come into play: political considerations and economic interests. Therefore, I believe that the US is actively seeking a solution to this problem.

Q. What do you make of President Zelensky? He was promised NATO, the European Union promised him the EU. But nothing really happened. Was NATO ever on the table for Ukraine?
A. When this gentleman came to power, he declared that he would pursue peace at all costs, using every means possible, without sparing even his career. But now we see things differently. He follows the same pattern as his predecessors—putting the interests of a narrow nationalist group, particularly radical nationalists, ahead of those of the people. Essentially, he is addressing their concerns rather than those of the nation. This regime’s mindset truly resembles a neo-Nazi regime because extreme nationalism and neo-Nazism are almost indistinguishable concepts. Today, undeniably, military action dominates their approach. However, they haven’t achieved much success here either. I have already said before that what matters most for them is realising that the best way to resolve the problems is through peaceful negotiations, and we attempted to negotiate with them back in 2022. What exactly they plan to do remains to be asked from them directly.

Q. Is NATO expansion a real threat or just a pretext for a part of Ukraine you probably want control over?
A. NATO is another matter altogether. The Russian language, Russian culture, religion, and even territorial issues—these are very important topics, one subject. NATO is something entirely different. We don’t demand anything exclusive for ourselves here. First of all, there are general agreements that the security of one state cannot be guaranteed by undermining the security of others. This idea might seem somewhat obscure, but I’ll explain it simply. Each country, including Ukraine, has the right to choose its own means of defence and ensure its own safety. Correct? Absolutely correct. Do we deny Ukraine this? No. But it’s not acceptable if done at Russia’s expense. Ukraine believes it would benefit from joining NATO. And we say: that threatens our security, let’s find a way to secure yours without threatening us. Secondly, we are not asking for anything unusual or unexpected, nothing falling from the sky. We are just insisting on fulfilling the promises already made to us. These weren’t invented yesterday. They were pledged to